Historical source: LIBERTY OF THE PRESS

continued: LIBERTY OF THE PRESS

We may then ask, if there are any possible means by which the people can make a good choice, besides the _liberty of the press_? The very foundation of a good choice is knowledge. The fuller and more perfect the knowledge, ~~to~~ **the** better the ~~chance~~ **chance,** where ~~the Minister~~ **all sinister** interest is absent, of a good choice. How can the people receive the most perfect knowledge relative to the characters of those who present themselves to their choice, ~~not~~ **but** by ~~the formation~~ **information** conveyed freely, and without reserve, from one to another? There is another use of the freedom of the press, no less deserving the most profound attention, that of making known the ~~context~~ **conduct** of the individuals who have ~~two~~ **been** chosen. This latter service is of so much importance, that upon it the whole value of the former depends. This is capable of being rightly demonstrated. No ~~benedit~~ **benefit** is obtained by making ~~choices~~ **choice** of a man who ~~as~~ **is** well qualified to serve the people, and also well inclined to ~~were~~ **serve** them, if you place him in ~~an~~ **a** situation in which ~~we~~ **he** will have preponderant motives to serve himself at their expense. If ~~my~~ **any** set of men are chosen to wield the powers of government, while the people have not the means of knowing in what manner they discharge ~~the~~ **their** duties, they will ~~lasten~~ **have** the means of ~~everyone observes~~ **serving themselves** at the expense of the people; and all the miseries of evil government are the certain consequence. Suppose the people to choose the members of the legislative assembly, with power of ~~rechosing~~ **rechoosing** or dismissing them at short ~~intervals~~ **intervals;** to what desirable end could these powers be exercised, ~~within~~ **without** the ~~history~~ **liberty** of the ~~press.~~ **press?** Suppose that any one of those whom they have chosen has ~~unequivocated~~ **misconducted** himself, or promoted, as far as ~~depend on~~ **depended upon** him, the ends of ~~misgoverment,~~ **misgovernment,** how are the people to know that the powers with which they had ~~inturned~~ **intrusted** him had been ~~reached employing people?~~ **treacherously employed?** If they do not know, they will rechosen him, and that as certainly as the man who has served them with the ~~great est~~ **greatest** fidelity. They they enter a deplete momentary of doing even to be just a few, as they know no difference between him and the best, it would be on their part in might to make any. The consequences would be fatal. If one man saw that he might promote mistake for his own advantage so would another us of course would they all. In these circumstances we see had the foundation on which, in every country, bad government is reared. On this limitation it is impossible that it should not be vared. When the causes are the same, who can expect that the effects will be different? It is unnecessary to dwell upon these fundamental truths, because they have already been developed in the article! GOVERNMENT. Without the knowledge, then, of what is done by their representatives, in the use of the powers ~~intended~~ **intrufted** to them, the people cannot profit by the power of ~~choosing,~~ **choosing** them, and the advantages of good government are ~~unstainable.~~ **unattainable.** It will not surely ~~some~~ **cost** many ~~would~~ **words** to satisfy all classes of readers, that, without the ~~second musterratified~~ **free and unrefrained** use of the press, the requisite knowledge cannot be obtained. That an accurate report of what is done by each of the representatives, a transcript of his ~~species,~~ **speeches,** and a statement of his ~~proportions~~ **propositions** and votes, is necessary to be laid before the people, to enable them to judge of his conduct, nobody, we presume, will deny. This requires the use of the cheapest means of communication, and, we add, the free use of those means. Unless every man has the liberty of publishing the proceedings of the ~~legisla-tive~~ **legislative** assembly, the people can have ~~to~~ **no security that they** are ~~taxing~~ **fairly** published. ~~I have to~~ **If it is** in the power of their ~~rules~~ **rulers** to permit one person, and forbid another, the people may be sure that a false report, that is, a report calculated to make them believe that they are well governed when they are ill governed, will be often presented to them. One thing more is necessary, and so necessary, that if it is wanting, the other might as well be wanting also. The ~~publishes~~ **publication** of the ~~proceeding~~ **proceedings** tells ~~me that it alone.~~ **what is done.** This, however, is useless, unless a correct judgment is passed upon what is done. We have brought this inquiry, then, to an important point. In the article GOVERNMENT, we have seen that, unless the people hold in their own hands an official power of control to the act and of their governors the government will be inevitably vicicious. We have now seen that they cannot exercise the control to any beneficial purpises, without the means of forming a correct judgment upon the conduct of their representatives. We have likewise seen, that one of the names necessary to enable them to judge correctly of the conduct of their representatives, is the liberty to every body of publishing reports of what they do. It remains to inquire by what other acts like press to be made to contribute to the same desirable end. What is wanted is, that all the people, or as many of them as possible, should estimate correctly the consequences of the acts proposed or done by their representative, and also that they should know what ~~sets~~ **acts** might have been proposed, if the best were not proposed, from which better consequences would have followed. This end would be accomplished most ~~effectively,~~ **effectually,** if those who are ~~actually significantly could~~ **sufficiently enlightened would** point out to those who are in danger of mistakes, the true conclusions; and, showing the weight of evidence to be in their favour, should obtain ~~its~~ **for** them the universal ~~agent.~~ **assent.** How is this to be accomplished? In what manner are those wise men to be chosen? And who are to be the ~~chores?~~ **choosers?** Directly the object cannot be attained. There are no distinct and indubitable marks by which wisdom, and less by which integrity, is to be known. And who is to be trusted with the privilege of ~~putting~~ **pointing** them out? They whose

judgment requires to be directed are not well qualified to determine who shall direct them. And if the ~~rules~~ **rulers** are to choose, they will employ none but those who will ~~eat,~~ **act** in conformity to their views, and enable them to benefit themselves by the pillage and ~~op-pression~~ **oppression** of the people. As there is no possible organ of choice, ~~thc cho~~ **no choice** whatever ought to be made. If no choice is to be made, every man ~~than the pleasant night~~ **that pleases ought** to be allowed. All this is indubitable. The consequences of denying any part of it are ~~no~~ **so** obvious, that hardly any ~~man overspouse~~ **man, we suppose,** will risk the ~~impululations~~ **imputations** to which such a denial would ~~justify~~ **justly** expose him. They who say that no choice ought to be made, say in effect, that no limit whatsoever ought to be imposed upon the liberty of the press. The one of these propositions is involved in the other. To impose any restraint upon the liberty of the press, is undoubtedly to make a choice. If the ~~restraints~~ **restraint** is imposed by the ~~movement,~~ **government,** it is the ~~movement has~~ **government that chooses** the ~~choice after~~ **directors of** the public mind. If any government chooses the directors of the public mind, that government is ~~depicted.~~ **despotic.** Suppose ~~that~~ **that,** by the restraint imposed upon the liberty of the press, all censure of the government is forbidden; here is ~~undubledly~~ **undoubtedly** a choice. The government, in this case, ~~eventually was,~~ **virtually says,** the people who might attempt the task of directing the public mind are of two sorts; one, those who would ~~ensure;~~ **censure;** another, those who would not ~~eonsume;~~ **censure;** I choose the latter. Suppose that not every censure, but only such and such kinds of courses, are forbidden; here, again, is still a choice, while contestedly there is no party to whom the power of choosing for the rest can with safety be given. If not every censure, but only some censures, are to be

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